

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD September 15th 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, GENERAL COUNCIL

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), General Council (GC) was convened on Monday, September 15th at 6:00 PM held in the SouthRec North Conference room and Zoom.

1. Call to Order

Present at the meeting were the following members of the:

- **(6) GPSC Executive Board (EB):** Mourad Abdennebi (President), Naama Levy (Administrative Vice President), Travis Dean (Executive Vice President), Mehrdad Aghayari (Assembly Chair), Milad Hasankhani (Treasurer), Rishabh Bhattad (Secretary)
- **(22) GPSC General Council (GC):** Anna Roche, Harriet Olulo, Anam Rani Khaldi, Max Thomas, Sarah Low, Joanna Joseph, Mohamadreza Ramenazi, Breanne Harvey, John Conley, Theodore Lowell, Xuelun Tian, J Bryce Palmer, Matt Sandoval, Esha Rajadhyaksha, Amanda Chriswell, Ben Armentrout, Precious Innocent Mastala - proxy for Kinsey Cline, Holly Thomas, Ryan Seal, Lucia Luna Aurelia, Hannah Szoke, Manglam Srivastav.
- **(4) Advisors and Staff:** Solange Quintana, Elham Chelabi, Roselyn Amamoo, David Bradshaw

Quorum met: 28 Officers present

2. Call to Audience

The EB may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (August 18, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- **President (Mourad Abdennebi):**
 - **Stipend Increase:** Had a productive meeting with the CFO, who agreed a 5-10% stipend increase is "doable" for this fiscal year. The conversation has now been moved to the Graduate College to discuss implementation with the deans.
 - **Counseling Services:** Met with the Director of CAPS. The possibility of GPSC covering co-pays was discussed, but the focus is on advocating for the

Graduate College to either fund this or establish on-site counselors at the Graduate Center.

- **Campus Safety:** The Chief of University Police will be invited to a future GC meeting to hear from and build relationships with graduate students.
- **Rec Center:** Plans are underway for graduate wellness and sports events in collaboration with the Rec Center. An ad hoc committee will be formed to lead this.
- **Administrative Vice President (Naama Levy):**
 - Attended the Faculty Senate meeting, where a proposal was discussed to create enforcement mechanisms to hold mid-level administrators accountable for ethical conduct and conflicts of interest. GPSC needs to identify its representative on the Committee of Eleven to monitor this.
 - A standardized constituency survey has been finalized and distributed. All representatives are urged to complete it and share it widely.
 - Helped organize "Disorientation," a well-attended event held in partnership with the United Campus Workers union.
- **Executive Vice President (Travis Dean):**
 - Met with the Executive Director of Campus Stores and confirmed the 20% discount for faculty/staff applies to all GAs, code can be used online.
 - The Campus Store will provide a drop-off bin for the cap-and-gown rental program and can offer discount coupons for GPSC events.
 - A monthly "Committee Engagement Update" Google Form has been created for reps to report their activity.
- **Treasurer (Milad Hasankhani):**
 - It was reported that all representatives should have received their first stipend payment. Any representative who has not should follow up with the Treasurer.
- **Assembly Chair (Mehrdad Aghayari):**
 - Previous meeting's recordings are available in the Box folder.
 - Requested that representatives provide advance notice if they plan to attend a meeting via Zoom to assist with technology setup and attendance tracking.
 - Urged Zoom attendees to use their full, correct names for attendance purposes.
- **Secretary (Rishabh Bhattad):**
 - Meeting minutes are up-to-date in the Box folder.
 - A tracking spreadsheet is being developed to monitor the status and priority of all GPSC projects and initiatives.

5. Internal Committee Reports

- The EVP reported that all committees have now had or will shortly have their first meeting.
- The general expectation is for committees to meet twice per month (every other week).
- The monthly Committee Engagement Update form must be filled out by the last day of each month.
- **Policy (Elham Chelabi):** A safety training for international students is available. Representatives were urged to submit public comments on a new federal policy change that would reduce the "duration of status" for international student visas.
- **Grants (Roselyn Amamoo):** B&M and Completion grants are being processed. Travel and PPG grants are still open.
- **Communications (Solange Quintana):** A template email is available for reps to introduce themselves to their constituents and share the new survey.

6. Old Business

- **Expanded Hours for Campus Pantry:** After initial pushback, the Dean of Students office has helped secure \$30,000 to expand pantry services. GPSC contributed \$5,000. A new staff member will be hired, with changes expected by late October.
- **Emergency Hardship Fund:** The fund is now open to all graduate students, including international students, with an award cap of \$1,500.
- **Writing Skills Improvement Program (WSIP):** The President met with the Dean of Humanities, who confirmed the program was cut for financial reasons. The proposed solution is to advocate for merging WSIP's professional services with the Graduate Writing Lab. This will be discussed further with the Graduate Center.

7. New Business & Action Items

- **Special Election for At-Large Representative:**
 - Motion to hold a special election by Mehrdad. Seconded by Mourad.
 - Candidate: Ella Stephan, a first-year MPH student, gave a statement highlighting her experience in student government, fundraising, and community outreach.
 - Vote: The council moved to a vote.
 - Result: Ella Stephan was elected with 28 votes in favor. She was sworn into office immediately.
- **GPSC Advocacy Project Prioritization:**



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Graduate & Professional Student Council

- The council participated in a collaborative Padlet session to identify and vote on key advocacy priorities for the year.
- The initiative to increase the baseline stipend received the most support and was identified as the number one goal for the year.
- Other popular topics included mental health support (CAPS) and community engagement. For CAPS, Rep. Joanna mentioned that through the collective efforts of representatives from Engineering, students from College of Engineering(COE) don't have to pay for counselling. The funds were allocated from COE Dean's funds. She encouraged and offered to provide resources to representatives from other constituencies to implement the same.
- A pop-up pantry is now available in the GPSC house for students to take snacks or make donations. The Executive Board will create a plan for its organization and maintenance.
- **Student Health Insurance Advisory Committee (SHIAC):**
 - Two representative spots are open on this committee. Rep. Lucia and Rep. Ben volunteered to serve.
- **Discussion for Central vs. College-Wise Constituent Meetings:**
 - A discussion was held on the effectiveness of individual college-level constituent meetings due to low attendance. The idea of a single, large, centrally-organized constituent event was proposed.
 - Outcome: The consensus was that rather than creating a new event, GPSC should focus on better advertising the existing General Council meetings as the primary forum for all graduate students to voice concerns.

8. Constituency Concerns & Meeting Modality

- It was announced that there is still one vacant GPSC representative seat on the **Student Services Fee Advisory Board**. This committee is crucial as it votes on the funding GPSC receives for its grants.

9. Motion to Adjourn

- Motion to adjourn the meeting by Mehrdad:
 - Seconded by Joanna.
 - The meeting was adjourned at 7:08 pm.

Dated this 15th day of September 2025

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary